Chapter Fifteen

The Last Fatimid Caliph

Between 1149 and 1171, Nur ad-Din captures Egypt, but Saladin rules it

THE HOLY WAR was failing, but the *jihad* was gathering strength.

With most of Antioch's territory in his hands, and the Crusaders out of his way, Nur ad-Din rode onwards to the coast and bathed himself in the Mediterranean. It was a symbolic baptism, first carried out by the Assyrian conqueror Sargon centuries before, meant to show that his dominance—now, the dominance of Islam—covered the entire land of Syria, all the way to the sea.[1]

In fact, he didn't control all of Syria; the city of Antioch itself was still free of his control, as were both Damascus and Jerusalem. But Nur ad-Din was now, in the eyes of his coreligionists, the flowering of his father's goal: the head of the *jihad*, the hope for the future of Islam's unity, the narrow wedge that would bring the Prophet's hope to the world. He was Champion of the Faith, his followers boasted: the Pillar of Islam, the Vanquisher of the Rebels.[2]